piece they make.Hand-crafted from leather, vegetable-dyed, ubiquitous but unique, these artefacts come from the hammers and awls of artisans in Karvir, Shirol, Kagal and Hatkanangale in Maharashtra's Kolhapur district. A heritage with a distinct socio-economic footprint.

THE DALIT DESIGNER

Kolhapuri's origin story is linked to caste reform: from Basavanna, the 12th century Lingayat poet-philosopher, up to Shahu Maharaj of Kolhapur at the turn of the 20th century, who set up 29 tanning centres to help uplift the Dalit communities involved in its production. From that cultural web came the issue of protecting the genuine article, and its authors, in the modern marketplace.

Prada hadn't yet stepped onto the stage. Cheaper local lookalikes were the first threat. In 2019, four districts each in Maharashtra and Karnataka—Kolhapur, Sangli, Solapur and Satara; and Belgaum, Dharwad, Bagalkot and Bijapur—were granted the Geographical Indication (GI) tag for the Kolhapuri brand. It isn't nearly enough. Sachin Satpute, a fourth-gen wielder of the craft, says cheaper versions made in places like Athani in Karnataka or Agra in UP pose a long-term danger to the 20,000-odd traditional artisans in Kolhapur. "There's a vast difference in quality. Counterfeit Kolhapuris use artificial leather or goat and sheep skin. They wear out soon, eroding the brand name and demand," he says. Real Kolhapuris use buffalo or bullock hide: more expensive but durable. Machine-made fakes that use cardboard pose a different challenge. "They can make 10-15 pairs a day. We design and stitch by hand, say, one pair in three days."

Takeaways

- **Prada's Rs 1.2 lakh Kolhapuri style sandals gets flak for 'cultural appropriation'**
- **Kolhapuri sandals has GI tag, but little done to market it, improve lot of craftsmen**

With an anarchic domestic market not yet sorted out, global ripoffs add a layer of complication that India seems not yet ready for. Could Prada have done the same with, say, France's Champagne? Very unlikely. In 2023, the French police destroyed 35,000 sparkling wine bottles wrongfully labelled as champagne. Parmesan, Feta, British Stilton blue cheese—all have similar protection. They have to originate in their regions to earn the label.

Even the Japanese kimono, not a GI, exercises a level of cultural sovereignty that foreign brands can't dare violate—as Kim Kardashian realised in 2019. But here, in remarks redolent with irony in the light of Pradagate, third-generation Kolhapuri maker Shivaji Satpute says traditional artisans like him are still "unable to command a premium". ■

—with Sonal Khetarpal



Takeaways

- **Surprise inspection at fertiliser factory in Ajmer shows large-scale adulteration**
- **Statewide drive shows rot is pervasive—fertilisers, pesticides, seeds. Of 57 tests in Meena's presence, 56 failed**

Shivraj Singh Chouhan, listing his findings. In it, he flagged the fact that it was a nationwide issue, citing the absence of raw seed source records, batch-wise pesticide analysis and evidence of banned and illegally imported products from China. He has also put on record that "low-quality inputs are being sold in 16-20 states in India".

RUFFLING FEATHERS

Known for his combative style, the former MP and six-time MLA has long thrived as a street-smart grassroots leader, often critical of governments while being part of them. Meena had stayed away from office for nearly 10 months during the BJP's current term, protesting his alleged sidelining. Cajoled by the party high command, he resumed office in April.

His activism has ruffled many feathers. Ex-CM Ashok Gehlot of the Congress, in a sly jab, said: "If ministers are conducting raids themselves, why do we need officers? And if the BJP finds it acceptable, maybe the CM and all the ministers should do this. It could be a new governance model." Meena, though, shrugs off the criticism: "I don't want to play politics. I'm just doing my duty, acting on corruption plaints." ■